SESSION 3

Stakeholder Mapping + Research Planning

Design Thinking for MBAs (Hybrid Section)

Thursday, March 12, 2026 | 6:30 PM | Online (Zoom) | Faculty: Patrick Ray

Check-In

Quick round: Has anything shifted in your thinking since Session 2?

What did writing about your observation experience surface?

10 minutes

> "By the end of tonight, your team will have a research plan. The next two weeks are fieldwork."

Tonight's Arc

Two breakout room cycles, two deliverables:

Stakeholder Mapping

- Identify 4-5 stakeholders for your scenario
- Include at least one **extreme user**
- Map concerns, constraints, access

Research Planning

- Design your two-week distributed plan
- Map each member's unique access
- Leave with specific assignments

Find the Duct Tape: Document one workaround or improvised fix in your notebook this week.

Stakeholder Mapping

Breakout rooms by team. Identify 4-5 stakeholders for your scenario.

For each stakeholder:

1. Who are they? (specific: "night shift warehouse supervisor," not "employee")
2. What do they optimize for?
3. What constraints do they face?
4. What are their top 2-3 concerns?
5. Which team member can access this stakeholder type?

Include at least one **extreme user**: someone who experiences the problem most intensely.

25 minutes

What Makes a Good Stakeholder Map?

Go Specific

- Not "customers" but **"first-time parents buying online"**
- Not "employees" but **"mid-career nurses on night shift"**
- The more specific, the more useful your research will be

Find Extreme Users

- Who experiences this problem **most intensely**?
- Who has a **workaround**?
- Who has **given up** on the existing solution?
- These perspectives reveal what normal users won't tell you

Debrief: The Overlooked Stakeholder

Back to main room. Each team shares one stakeholder they almost forgot or didn't initially consider.

15 minutes

- Why do we overlook certain stakeholders?
- What makes some invisible?
- "Learning From Others" means seeking perspectives you wouldn't naturally encounter

> "The stakeholders you overlook are often the ones with the most revealing perspective."

The Method Transition

From observation to empathy interviews

Observation → Interviews

In TETHER, you practiced pure observation: watching without asking. That discipline matters, and you'll keep using it.

Now you add a new tool: **the empathy interview.**

Observation Shows

- **What** people do
- Behaviors, patterns, workarounds
- The visible surface of the problem

Interviews Reveal

- **Why** they do it
- Motivations, constraints, frustrations
- The invisible logic underneath

You need both. You've mapped stakeholders on paper. Now you actually talk to them.

The Distributed Advantage

Your team's superpower is that you're in **different places.**

- Different cities
- Different workplaces
- Different industries

Each of you can reach stakeholders the others can't.

> That's not a limitation of the hybrid format. It's the strategy.

Research Planning

Back to breakout rooms. Create a concrete research plan for the next two weeks.

1. Who can each team member **reach**? Map your combined access.
2. What will each person **do**? (Observation, interview, or both)
3. What specific **questions** or observation targets for each stakeholder?
4. How will you **coordinate** async? (Slack, GroupMe, text, shared doc)
5. When will you **compile** findings? (Must be before Session 4, March 26)

Each member: 1-2 substantial observations or interviews. **Depth, not breadth.**

25 minutes

What a Good Research Plan Looks Like

Not "we'll do some research." Instead:

Sarah interviews two pediatric nurses at Houston Methodist (week 1). Shares notes in team Google Doc by March 20.

Marcus observes shift handoff at his company's warehouse in Dallas (March 14). Posts photos + field notes by March 17.

Team sync: 30-min Zoom on March 22 to compile findings before Session 4.

Names. Dates. Stakeholders. Coordination method. Compile deadline.

Share Research Plans

Back to main room. Each team briefly shares:

- Who's doing what, and where?
- What's your coordination plan?
- When will findings be compiled?

10 minutes

The Research Period

March 12 - 26

- Each team member conducts **1-2 substantial** observations or interviews
- Focus on **depth**, not breadth
- Document in your notebook; contribute to your team's shared document
- Coordinate with your team asynchronously

Due Session 4 (March 26)

- **Stakeholder Research**: Compiled team research document
- **Causal Loop Map**: Diagram of problem dynamics, feedback loops, who benefits

Not a Survey

- Don't send a Google Form to 50 people
- Talk to 1-2 stakeholders in depth
- Observe in context when possible
- Quality of insight over quantity of data

What's Next

- **Session 4**: Thursday, March 26, 6:30 PM (Online, Zoom)
- Synthesize research, build causal loop maps, define the problem
- Use the two-week gap to conduct research in your own environments

> "The next two weeks are yours. Use them."

Find the Duct Tape: Each week, identify and document one workaround or improvised fix in your notebook.